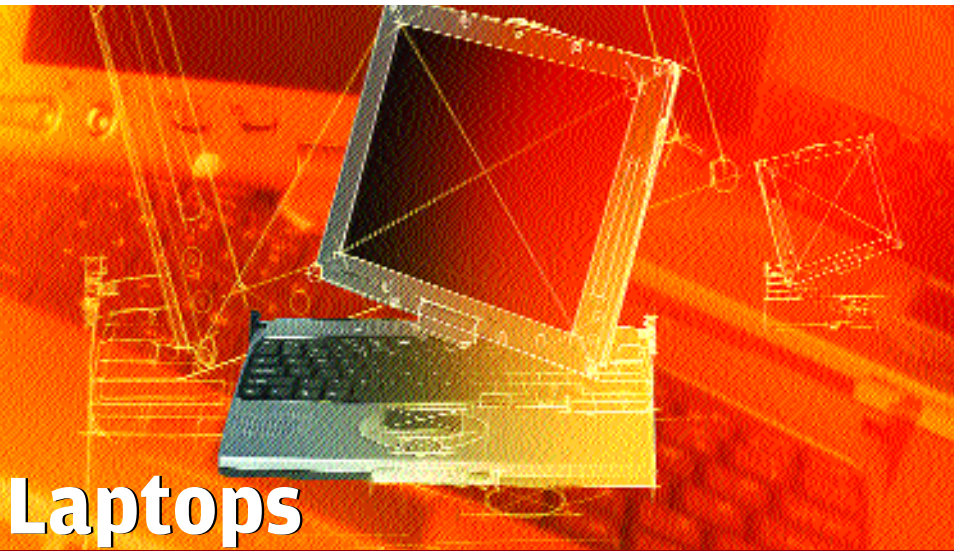




The trend in laptops is towards thin, slim and light. We already have laptops an inch thick. Newer laptops come with better battery life, thanks to technology such as SpeedStep processors, video cards that blank out unused bits of hardware, low-power hard drives, and so on. In the future, the advancement in the laptop will further reduce power consumption and give longer battery life.

nVidia has introduced MXM modules, which are nothing but replaceable graphic cards. Future laptops that will use this

approach can upgrade the graphics subsystem, and update it just like in desktops. Storage may change from removable disks (floppy, Zip, CD, and DVD) to solid-state memory, which would make them even lighter and thinner.

Do Remember

❑ Don't buy a laptop that has the drive located in the front.

❑ Make sure that the laptop design allows for proper air ventilation. This is very important for crash-free working and long hardware life.



Buying Tips

- ✓ **PROCESSOR:** Pentium M, Pentium IV M and Athlon Mobile processors are available for the laptop segment, with the Pentium offering the best performance-to-power consumption ratio.
- ✓ **UPGRADABILITY:** This may not occur to you when you purchase a laptop, but it's important all the same. Here are some options to look for when upgrading your laptop—the RAM, the CPU, the hard drive, etc. Are the upgrades something you can do yourself, or do they require visits to a service centre?
- ✓ **LOCATION:** Before you buy a laptop, make sure you can easily return it to the dealer if it proves unsatisfactory. Also check if the dealer can service your laptop. If he can't, where's the nearest location your laptop can be serviced?
- ✓ **BATTERY:** The uptime for most Lithium-ion battery powered laptops is about three to four hours. Purchase a spare battery in case you happen to use your notebook for a period longer than that—say, while travelling.
- ✓ **KEYBOARD:** If you do a lot of numeric typing along with regular typing, a numeric keyboard is what you need to look for. Go for one with a

USB connection, as the connection is plug-and-play and can be safely hot-plugged.

- ✓ **DRIVES OR BAYS:** Though it makes sense to have all drives such as the floppy drive and the DVD/CD-ROM drive built into the main casing, a hot-swappable bay gives you greater flexibility.
- ✓ **DOCKING STATIONS:** This is useful if you are using an ultra-portable system that does not have basic I/O ports and drives. However, not all notebook models give you this option.
- ✓ **COMMUNICATION:** Go for an inbuilt 56K modem. If you need to connect to a network, you will also need an inbuilt, or a PCMCIA-based, Ethernet port. Also consider Wi-Fi support, as it is getting common.
- ✓ **POINTING DEVICE:** You can choose between a pointing stick or a touch pad. Pointers are easier to control, but can give you a sore finger.
- ✓ **HARD DRIVE:** Capacities range from 30 GB to 60 GB. Most users find 20 GB enough.
- ✓ **CARRY CASE:** A sturdy carry case, preferably one that opens only from the top, is essential. These are available in various types and sizes. Some also serve as overnight travel bags.

Ready Reckoner

 Low-end You Need	A purely functional device at an affordable price
Look for	A model that has an extra bay that can hold a CD/DVD-ROM, floppy drive, add-on battery or even a CD-RW drive.
 Mid-end You Need	Something that gives high performance, and has several extra features as well
Look for	Something that gives you all the functionality of your desktop PC
 High-end You Need	An ultra-light notebook; something with a little panache
Look for	Extremely lightweight devices that are different from the rest of the crowd



❑ Many laptops offer large screens and can work as desktop replacements. But the larger the screen, the more difficult it will be to use the laptop in cramped locations, such as in an airplane or car.

❑ "Refurbished" is a term used to describe a laptop, or any hardware device, that contains one or more components that have been used and/or repaired. Refurbished laptops are lower-priced, and are generally a good deal for budget-conscious buyers. However, such laptops are available through local dealers and not the vendors themselves.

❑ Although most manufacturers today tend to reduce the amount of documentation included with laptops, all manufacturers will include some type of paper documentation or paper inserts. Check if this includes information on upgrading, connecting the cables, and how to use the bundled software.